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# NO GOOD TALIBAN?

## INDIA'S TALIBAN LEARNING CURVE

'We favour neither India nor Pakistan ... We are not saying that India should get out of Afghanistan. Nor can India be completely expelled from Afghanistan. The Taliban aren't in any direct conflict with India. Indian troops aren't part of NATO forces, they haven't occupied Afghanistan ... It's possible for the Taliban and India to reconcile with each other. Our complaint is that India backed the NA [Northern Alliance], and is now supporting the Karzai government.'

Zabiullah Mujahid, Spokesperson of the Taliban, April 2010[1]

'New Delhi has come around to accepting dialogue with those Taliban elements who are prepared to renounce violence ... But New Delhi is wary of those who, under Pakistani tutelage, might pretend to be reborn constitutionalists, but seize the first opportunity after the American withdrawal to devour the regime that compromises with them.'

Shashi Tharoor, MoS External Affairs (2009–10), Congress Lok Sabha MP, and Chairman of Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs.[2]

### *No good Taliban?*

India's understanding of and approach towards the Afghan Taliban evolved considerably over the course of the war after 2002. Though New Delhi remained wary of legitimising the Afghan Taliban, it grew conscious of the hazards of viewing it as a monolithic entity subservient to Pakistan's interests and political